Native Americans

The story of Native Americans begins thousands of years before the Europeans set off across the wide stretch of ocean to discover a great unknown continent. North America was actually colonized by a group of people who left Asia. They crossed over a bridge from modern day Siberia and reached today's Alaska around twelve thousand years ago. These settlers were the ancestors of the Native Americans whom the Europeans discovered several centuries ago.

The initial settlers who trekked from Asia consisted of only a few thousand. When the Europeans arrived in North America, the native population had grown much larger. There is some dispute among scholars as to the exact number but it is estimated that between 7 and 18 million natives were present in North America before European colonization. Other studies show that around 10 million natives lived in the region that is now considered to be the United States of America.

Over time, these settlers quickly spread across the eastern- southern regions and established themselves on the new land. Archaeologists and anthropologists have separated the continent into separate regions where different groups of natives practiced similar customs and lifestyles. Academics have divided North America, into ten areas: the Plateau, the Northwest Coastal region, the Great Basin, the Plains, California, the Southeast, the Southwest, the Northeast, the Subarctic and the Arctic regions. It is important to note that Mexico is not included in these regions.